

PMI-ACP EXAM AT A GLANCE

Items	120 total — 100 scored, 20 unscored pretest
Time	3 hours
Break	One 10-minute break after item 60; you cannot return to earlier items
Formats	Multiple choice, multiple response, drag-and-drop, exhibits
Blueprint	Current PMI-ACP Exam Content Outline (March 2026 edition)
Tutorial/survey	Optional and not counted against the 3 hours

DOMAIN WEIGHTS (CURRENT ECO)

Domain	Share of items
1. Mindset	28%
2. Leadership	25%
3. Product	19%
4. Delivery	28%

TIP The March 2026 ECO is framework-agnostic and adds enterprise agility: align work with organisational priorities, optimise end-to-end flow, coordinate across teams and engage stakeholders. Mindset and Leadership together are 53%.

THE FOUR MANIFESTO VALUES

- Individuals and interactions over processes and tools.
- Working software over comprehensive documentation.
- Customer collaboration over contract negotiation.
- Responding to change over following a plan.
- The right-hand items still have value — the left is valued more.

PRINCIPLES WORTH MEMORISING

- Satisfy the customer through early and continuous delivery of value.
- Welcome changing requirements, even late.
- Deliver working increments frequently, on the shortest scale that works.
- Build around motivated people and trust them to get the job done.
- Face-to-face conversation is the most effective way to convey information.
- Working product is the primary measure of progress.
- Sustainable pace, technical excellence, simplicity, self-organising teams.
- The team tunes its own behaviour at regular intervals.

SCRUM TIMEBOXES (1-MONTH SPRINT)

Event	Timebox
Sprint	1 month or less
Sprint planning	Up to 8 hours
Daily scrum	15 minutes
Sprint review	Up to 4 hours
Retrospective	Up to 3 hours

FRAMEWORKS IN ONE LINE

Framework	Core idea
Scrum	Fixed-length sprints, three accountabilities, empirical control
Kanban	Visualise flow, limit WIP, pull, manage queues
XP	Engineering discipline: pairing, TDD, refactor, continuous integration
Lean	Eliminate waste, build quality in, optimise the whole
Crystal	Tailor ceremony to team size and criticality
Scrumban	Scrum cadence with Kanban flow limits
Scaling (SoS, LeSS, SAFe)	Coordinate work and dependencies across multiple teams at scale

WHO DOES WHAT

- Product owner: single voice for value, owns and orders the backlog.
- Scrum master / coach: facilitates, removes impediments, protects the process.
- Developers: own the estimate, the sprint plan and the technical quality.
- Stakeholders give feedback through appropriate channels throughout the sprint, including the review; they do not direct developers' work.
- Nobody assigns work to a self-organising team — the team pulls it.



METRICS AND MATHS

Little's Law	Cycle time = $WIP \div \text{throughput}$ With stable throughput and conditions, lower average WIP tends to lower average cycle time
Throughput	Items finished $\div$ time period
Velocity	Story points accepted per iteration Forecasting only — never a score
Iterations remaining	Remaining points $\div$ average velocity
Lead time	Customer request to delivery Cycle time starts when work begins
Escaped defect rate	Defects found after release $\div$ total defects Quality trend, not blame
Return on investment	$ROI = (\text{benefit} - \text{cost}) \div \text{cost}$ Informs prioritisation alongside risk, dependencies, learning and urgency

CHARTS: WHAT EACH ONE ANSWERS

- Burndown: how much work is left in the iteration or release.
- Burnup: work completed against a scope line, so scope creep is visible.
- Cumulative flow diagram: queues, work in progress and bottlenecks.
- Control chart: cycle-time spread and whether the process is stable.
- Information radiator: any big visible chart the team keeps current.

LEADERSHIP AND MINDSET

- Servant leader: remove impediments, shield the team, coach, do not assign tasks.
- The team decides how much it can take and how it will build it.
- Make work visible; let the data start the conversation.
- Fail fast and cheaply — a spike or prototype beats an argument.
- Psychological safety comes before honest retrospectives.
- Simple, complicated, complex, chaotic: match the response to the situation.

PRODUCT AND DELIVERY

- Let the product vision guide roadmap, release and iteration planning; refine each iteratively as learning changes priorities.
- Order the backlog to optimise value while weighing risk, dependencies, learning, urgency and size; the highest standalone-value item is not automatically first.
- A good story is independent, negotiable, valuable, estimable, small, testable.
- Minimum viable product exists to test a hypothesis, not to ship less.
- Use fit-for-purpose estimation: relative sizing and planning poker help under uncertainty, and time-based estimates can also be appropriate.
- A definition of ready is an optional team working agreement; the definition of done says when work is part of a usable increment, and it does not itself gate release.
- Limit work in progress, pull work, and finish before starting.

COMMON TRAPS

- Comparing velocity across teams — points are team-relative.
- Unnecessary mid-iteration disruption; scope may still be clarified and renegotiated during the sprint if the sprint goal is not endangered.
- The coach solving the problem rather than facilitating the team's solution.
- Treating the retrospective as optional when the team is busy.
- Calling a partly finished item "done" for reporting purposes.

TEST-DAY PLAN

1. About 90 seconds per item — flag and move rather than stall.
2. Choose the answer that increases transparency and team ownership.
3. Prefer collaboration and empiricism, while using escalation, governance and documentation when risk, compliance, safety or authority requires them.
4. Clear your flags before the break at item 60 — you cannot go back.
5. Answer everything; there is no penalty for a guess.

TIP Confirm item counts, timing and break rules in the current PMI Certification Handbook and PMI-ACP Exam Content Outline before your appointment.

